



Xpress 200 chipset based system, but was able to install 6.06 without problems—so a few compatibility issues have been sorted.

Ubuntu has yet again gone for the brown GNOME desktop—neat and clean—yet it might not suite everyone tastes.

With **Mandriva 2006**, our first installation attempt failed as the installer hung

mid way. On the second attempt, however, the installation was smooth without any glitches—strange! The Mandriva installer is quite straight forward and its partitioning tool (where most other Linux distros mess up), made sure things don't get dicey. As with last years experience, Mandriva 2006 was able to detect most of the hardware, including the Audigy card as well as the onboard high definition audio. Display resolution, frequency and aspect ratio of the display were perfectly set by default. Right from the onset, Mandriva has always preferred the KDE desktop and Mandriva 2006 is no exception.

SuSE Linux still has its slick YAST (Yet Another Setup Tool) installer and configuration tool. Not much has been changed in the new SuSE version, except for the new green background. The step-by-step menu approach and hints being displayed makes installing SuSE much easier for a novice. The partitioning, however, can use some refinement. The Installer also allows you to configure which applications to install right at the beginning—by default, some 2.5 GB of software is selected for installation. Hardware detection still isn't SuSE's forte, and SuSE needs to accommodate more hardware drivers. On our test machine it

failed to recognise the Samsung 798MB monitor and configured it with the wrong frequencies. Apart from the display, the rest of the hardware was properly detected. SuSE Linux, unlike its previous version, has defaulted to a slick GNOME desktop.

Fedora core 5 (the open source offshoot of Red Hat) has undergone a revolutionary change. The jazzy splash screen and the new logo give the otherwise boring granddaddy of Linux, a completely new look. On the partitioning screen, the installer surprised us with its intelligent selection and optimisation of space for installing Fedora. The manual partitioning tool is also pretty workable if the automatic detection fails. The best part about Fedora is its hardware detection capability; it detected and configured all the hardware we threw at it, which it also did in our test last year. Being in the business for such a long time gives Fedora the edge over its competitors when it comes to hardware compatibility. Fedora Core 5 defaults to a well laid-out, customised GNOME desktop.

Xandros Linux has done commendable work on its installer. The installer directly starts by detecting hardware and then moves on to present a license agreement! Yes, Xandros is a paid OS—hence the license agreement. The full graphical installer is unique in a sense; the interface resembles Windows 98 and is sure to make novices feel comfortable. It even goes to the extent of having 'Custom' and 'Express' options for installing the applications—excellent for those of us used to Windows-style installers. Partitioning is so simple in Xandros that we think Microsoft should take a leaf or two from these guys. We rate Xandros partitioning UI above everybody else because of its simple and yet functional approach. Hardware detection was good—we didn't encounter any problems with our hardware. Xandros default's to a well polished KDE desktop, which resembles a typical Windows desktop—makes it quite easy for a beginner to settle down fast.

How We Reviewed

Our review methodology took into account parameters such as ease of installation, ease of use, out of box usability and to some extent hardware support.

In ease of installation, we checked for how simple the installation process is. Does it allow you to choose empty space on the hard drive to install the new OS? How simple is the user interface for partitioning the drive? Does the installer provide any useful hints or information during partitioning of the drive? These parameters are quite critical for a beginner and may not be as important to a power user.

In terms of ease of use, we took into account general usability of the system. To start with we checked how simple it is to customise the system to your liking—wallpapers, screensavers, applying themes, changing fonts and their size, changing screen resolutions, etc. Once the system was set to our liking we moved on to setting up network connections, Proxy settings, configuring the e-mail client, configuring a printer. Then we checked sharing of folders on the network, browsing the LAN network, connecting to the Internet, updating the system by downloading new patches, etc. In the process we tried simulating typical PC usage.

For out of box usability, we looked at the bundled applications and whether there are enough of them to carry out your daily chores. We looked for an office suite that can be a viable replacement for MS Office, a messenger client to chat, a good browser for Internet browsing and some sort of image manipulation application. We also tried connecting a USB flash drive, a Digital camera to check for plug and play capability.

Right from the inception, hardware support has been a problem with Linux operating system due to unavailability of drivers. For us it is extremely difficult to test them on various hardware, so we decided to test these distro's on the latest hardware. The idea being if they work with latest hardware then there is relatively less chance that they might not work with older hardware. Our testbed comprised of an Intel 3.6 GHz Pentium 4 CPU, Intel D925PBX motherboard, 1 GB RAM, an MSI 7300GS graphics card, a Creative Audigy sound card, a 400 GB Hitachi SATA hard drive and Samsung's SyncMaster 798MB monitor. Another machine we used was the Dell D820 laptop with Intel Core Duo processor, 1GB memory, NVIDIA Quadro NV125 and a 100 GB hard drive.